

Presentism Trial Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 35-45 min

Category	History	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	presentism-trial

Big idea: Historical judgement involves ethical tension.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Presentism Trial Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Presentism Trial Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Presentism Trial Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Role cards for prosecution, defence, context witness, and judge. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Presentism Trial Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A verdict statement separating explanation from excuse. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Historical judgement involves ethical tension.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Presentism Trial Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Presentism Trial Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Should we judge the past by present standards?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards.
- Role cards for prosecution, defence, context witness, and judge.
- A verdict statement separating explanation from excuse.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Activity Steps

1. Put the historical case "on trial".
2. Half the class uses present-day values. Half uses values and constraints of the period.
3. The judge panel decides what each side understood and ignored.
4. Debrief the difference between explanation, justification and excuse.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Should we judge the past by present standards?
- Can understanding become excuse-making?
- What responsibilities do historians have when interpreting morally troubling evidence?

Knowledge Questions

- Should we judge the past by present standards?
- Can understanding become excuse-making?
- What responsibilities do historians have when interpreting morally troubling evidence?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...